

The Digest

Issue 2 · July 2026 · covering 10 June – 10 July 2026 · 8 min read

The offer economy's plumbing began to consolidate — retail-media alliances, an exchange, a first certification, an agent checkout thrown open — while what counts as a reward kept splintering.

£4.8bn

Forecast UK retail media ad spend for 2026, up from around £4bn in 2025 — the money this month's consolidation is being built to organise.

THIS MONTH

- 01 UK retail media stops fragmenting
- 02 The agent checkout opens to every merchant
- 03 Gulf banks build the rewards hub
- 04 What a reward is, re-priced
- + For the roadmap · also moving · what's next

Last month's story was new rails with no loyalty on them. This month the plumbing began to consolidate: UK retail media gained a cross-retailer alliance, its first exchange and its first certified network; Shopify threw the agent checkout open to every merchant; and two Gulf banks wired rewards into their apps. Yet what counts as a reward kept splintering — into experiences, membership tiers and closed-loop points that share less and less with plain cashback.

FOR THE ROADMAP

Most of this month is context. Two threads are grounded in what shipped — or pointedly didn't.

- 1 **Retail media gets an audited yardstick.** An independent certification for retail-media measurement went live in the UK — Nectar360 the first network to pass it — and the month's

alliance is built on shared measurement standards. → [Trend 01](#)

- 2 **The opening agent rails still have no loyalty object.** Shopify removed the approval gate and opened its checkout protocol to every developer — with offers, points and rewards nowhere in it, and the one standard for them unmoved since January. → [Trend 02](#)

01 TREND · COMMERCE MEDIA UK retail media stops fragmenting

The block on commerce media has always been fragmentation — every retailer a separate network, separate plans, separate numbers. This month four moves went at it from four directions: an alliance, an exchange, a first certification, and Amazon's ad stack arriving in UK grocery.

£4.8bn

FORECAST UK RETAIL MEDIA SPEND,
2026

4

RETAILERS IN ONE CROSS-RETAILER
ALLIANCE PILOT

1st

UK NETWORK TO EARN IAB EUROPE
CERTIFICATION

dunnhumby opens a single route across rival retailers

dunnhumby launched a network alliance giving brands and agencies one route to run campaigns across multiple retailers rather than rebuilding plans network by network — with Tesco, B&Q, John Lewis and Waitrose in the first pilots and ad-tech firm Kevel as the delivery partner. Retailers keep their own media businesses; what's shared is standards for activation, measurement and reporting.

Source: [dunnhumby](#) · [The Grocer](#)

SMG stands up the UK's first retail media exchange

SMG launched RMX, billed as the UK's first retail media exchange — a shared layer that lets brands plan, buy, activate and measure across multiple retail networks through a single entry point, while each retailer keeps control of pricing, inventory and data. Built with Empathy Lab by EPAM, it sits above the networks rather than replacing them.

Source: [InternetRetailing](#)

Amazon's ad stack lands in a UK grocer

Asda became the first retailer anywhere outside the US to license Amazon's Retail Ad Service, using Amazon's machine-learning ad tech to power sponsored products across Asda.com and George, with a phased rollout from Q4 2026. Asda isn't buying ads on Amazon — it is renting Amazon-grade targeting and measurement to run its own network.

Source: [Asda](#) · [Grocery Gazette](#)

Nectar360 clears the first UK certification

Nectar360 became the first UK retail media network to achieve IAB Europe's Retail Media Certification, following an independent ABC audit — covering its off-site display and video products.

It also reported early results from Pollen, its unified planning-to-measurement platform, with Unilever and Coca-Cola Europacific Partners on board.

Source: [IAB Europe](#) · [Retail Gazette](#)

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN PRODUCT →

The month's moves are as much about **measurement as reach**. IAB Europe's certification turns retail-media measurement from a vendor claim into an audited standard a network can be tested against, and dunnhumby's alliance is explicitly built on shared measurement and reporting rules across retailers. The yardstick a commerce-media proposition is judged by is becoming external and common, rather than each seller's own.

Sources: [IAB Europe](#) · [dunnhumby](#)

02 TREND · AGENTIC COMMERCE

The agent checkout opens to every merchant

Last month the card networks specified who an agent may pay. This month Shopify opened the checkout itself — dropping the approval gate so any developer can plug an agent into millions of merchants — and the offer still isn't an object in it.

Shopify drops the approval gate on agentic checkout

In its Spring '26 edition, Shopify removed the approval requirement for building on its agentic layer: developers can now register an agent profile in the Developer Dashboard and call Shopify's public MCP endpoint directly, with the Universal Commerce Protocol — co-developed with Google — carrying the flow from discovery through checkout, and higher trust tiers unlocking direct checkout completion. The plumbing for agents to transact across millions of merchants is now self-serve.

Source: [Shopify](#)

Offers are not in the protocol

What the release describes is discovery, a catalog API and checkout. What it does not describe — anywhere — is loyalty, offers, discounts or rewards as first-class objects. The one standard aimed squarely at making incentives readable to agents, Talon.One's Unified Incentives Protocol, has not shipped a new milestone since January. As the transacting surface opens up, the category's core objects remain outside it.

Source: [Shopify \(protocol scope\)](#)

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN PRODUCT →

The agent-transaction surface now reaches millions of merchants with no gatekeeper — and **an offer or a points balance is still not something an agent can read at that surface**. Last month the gap sat in the networks' trust layer; this month it sits in the commerce platform's

open checkout protocol too. The plumbing keeps being laid without the loyalty object, and the standard that would supply it has stalled.

Sources: [Shopify](#) · Talon.One UIP (no in-window movement since Jan 2026)

03 TREND · GCC · IN-HOUSE REWARDS

Gulf banks build the rewards hub

In the reader's Gulf sales region, two tier-one UAE banks shipped first-party rewards this month — one a lifestyle marketplace built in-house, one automated card-linked cashback bought from a vendor. Two answers to the same build-or-buy question, both live.

2	20%	Debit
TIER-ONE UAE BANKS SHIPPING FIRST-PARTY REWARDS	MASHREQ CARD-LINKED CASHBACK, UP TO	MASHREQ REWARDS REACH DEBIT FOR THE FIRST TIME

Emirates NBD builds a rewards marketplace in the app

The UAE's largest bank launched Rewards Hub inside its ENBD X app — a single in-app marketplace pulling rewards, travel, shopping, gifting and lifestyle into one place, built with Vernost. The launch ran up to 15% off flights, hotels and Apple products and a weekly AED 10,000 draw, with customers able to pay by card, redeem points, split the two, or spread cost over instalments.

Source: [Emirates NBD \(via Zawya\)](#)

Mashreq buys automated card-linked cashback from a vendor

Mashreq launched Everyday Cashback — automated, merchant-funded Visa card-linked offers of up to 20%, tracked in-app and personalised to the customer, and extended to debit cardholders for the first time. It is powered by third-party platform Rezolve Ai rather than built in-house: the exact card-linked-offer product this reader sells, bought off the shelf by a tier-one Gulf bank.

Source: [Mashreq](#)

WHY IT MATTERS

Two of the Gulf's biggest banks answered the build-or-buy question in the same month and split on it: **Emirates NBD built a lifestyle marketplace in-house through Vernost; Mashreq bought automated card-linked cashback from Rezolve Ai.** Both land in the reader's expansion region, and both are the category's own product shipping through a bank — one as an in-house build, one as a vendor deal. The competitive picture in the GCC is now first-party hubs and third-party CLO platforms at the same table.

What a reward is, re-priced

This month reward value pulled away from plain cashback in three directions at once — into curated experiences, into paid membership tiers, and into closed-loop points that can no longer be cashed out.

Barclays makes the headline reward an experience, not cash

Barclays' summer switching offer, live from 9 June, splits two ways: £200 in cash for standard switchers, or — for Premier customers — a £600 "signature experience" spanning Michelin-level dining, hotel stays and entertainment. Weekly "Barclays Experiences" perks (a GAIL's drink, four months of Apple Music) sit alongside. The premium reward is deliberately something cashback can't be.

Source: [MoneyfactsCompare](#)

ING packages rewards into paid tiers (Spain)

ING in Spain moved to a four-tier paid subscription model — Go, More, Extra and Max — with rewards weighted into the higher tiers, borrowing the premium-plan playbook of Revolut, N26 and Bunq. Loyalty value becomes something a customer subscribes to rather than earns per transaction. A Spanish-market move, but a template incumbents watch.

Source: [The Objective](#)

PayPal closes the loop on its points (US)

PayPal is ending cash redemption of PayPal Rewards from 1 August and requiring customers to actively opt in, pushing points into in-ecosystem redemption at checkout. It is a pointed data point on closed-loop versus open-loop reward value — and, judging by the reaction, on the backlash risk of taking cash-out away. A US programme, flagged as such.

Source: [PayPal](#)

WHY IT MATTERS

Three banks and wallets, three different answers to what a reward is *for*: **an experience you couldn't buy the same way (Barclays), a membership you pay to hold (ING), and points that only spend inside the house (PayPal)**. Each competes with a cashback or card-linked-offer proposition on a different axis — desirability, recurring revenue, and redemption control — and none of them is the flat percentage the category grew up on.

ALSO MOVING

Movement that didn't make a trend

- **UK bank rewards went quiet after last month's flurry.** Lloyds Rewards bedded in as it replaced Everyday Offers across Lloyds, Halifax and Bank of Scotland, but no new rewards launch landed from NatWest, HSBC, Santander, Nationwide, TSB, Monzo, Starling, Revolut or Chase in the window. *Lloyds Banking Group*
- **Bank of America bundled rewards with referrals, instalments and credit health** (10 June) — referral bonuses, a fixed-fee "Custom Pay Plan" and credit monitoring folded into one programme, widening "rewards" past cashback. *US. Bank of America*
- **Paytm and AU Small Finance Bank launched a co-branded card** weighting rewards to Paytm-ecosystem spend (3 July) — super-apps deepening bank tie-ups and steering earn to first-party rails. *India. Card Insider*
- **IHG tied hotel-loyalty earn to a Revolut debit card** in a UK promotion (30 June–25 August) — card-linked reward distribution routed through a neobank rather than a legacy bank. *The Wise Marketer*
- **Card-linked-offer infrastructure vendors were quiet.** No in-window product or partnership news from Cardlytics or Fidel API — a calm month for the reader's direct platform set. *competitor sweep, this issue*

WHAT'S NEXT

The forming picture

WATCH

dunnhumby's alliance pilots go live this summer across household & DIY, health & beauty and grocery — cross-retailer retail media moves from announced to running. *dunnhumby*

WATCH

Asda's Amazon Retail Ad Service rolls out from Q4 2026 — the first read on how Amazon-grade ad tech performs inside a UK grocery network. *Asda*

WATCH

More UK and EU networks line up for IAB Europe certification as the V1-to-V2 measurement-standard transition closes at the end of July — a standard consolidating in real time. *IAB Europe*

WATCH

Whether a loyalty or offer object reaches the agent rails — the Universal Commerce Protocol and Talon.One's UIP are where it would land as Shopify's open agent surface scales. *Shopify*

OPEN

UKPI Wave 2 brings general e-commerce onto the A2A scheme in H2 2026 — the recurring-payments coverage question becomes a checkout one. *Open Banking Expo*

PRODUCT EDITION

The Digest

Product signals for commerce, loyalty & payments — monthly

Next issue: August 2026